

The Double-Edged Relationship Between Sassanid Kings and Princes: Kinship and Political Rivalry

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Sassanid princes were considered legitimate heirs of the monarchy and the paramount practitioners and allies of the Šāh in the administration of imperial affairs due to their blood relationship with the Šāh. The princes who ruled the principal imperial states such as Armenia and Sīstān were also the utmost allies of the king in wars and functioned as a guarantor of political treaties through marriages which helped the king to resolve vital disputes and expand his power in the vast areas beyond previous borders of the Sassanid's empire. However, clergy and aristocracy had gradually seized a considerable part of the king's power by using numerous intrigues including inciting ambitious princes against an undesirable king. The impact of political considerations and benefits on the blood relationship between the Šāh and princes, eventually became one of the main reasons which led to the decline of the dynasty; therefore, examining the various dimensions of this extremely multifaceted relationship is essential to understand to what extent royal family relations, especially the father-son relationship, affected the efficiency and power of a king during the Sassanid era.

Keywords: Sassanian history, Sassanian dynasty, Sassanid princes, family in Sassanid period, father-son relationship, kinship, blood relationship.

Introduction

Since the royal family was part of the Sassanid society like any other family living under the territory of Sassanids, it is necessary to initially address the family context and sons' role in Sassanid society to comprehend the relationship between Sassanid kings and princes. This introduction can clarify the sensitive position of princes in the royal family as unique members of Sassanid society. The fact that the society was fundamentally based on the two pillars of property and blood relationship (Christensen, 2006, 228) made family the basic unit of loyalty and trust with full rights and absolute authority. Although attempts were made to establish other central units of power during the Sassanid period, the family remained the prime institution in Sassanid society (Frye, 1962, 217). The society consisted of lineages based on patriarchy. The oldest man who usually was the father or the grandfather (called Sālār) took responsibility for the extended family and made the crucial decisions which was also true for the royal family according to the evidence (Christensen, 2006, 242; Dezhmakhoo, 2012, 1-2; Mazdapour, 1991, 227-228). The Sālār's absolute power was to the extent that he was considered both the guardian and the owner

of his children, and they had to obey unquestioningly their father. If the children disobeyed their father three times or did not do their duty toward him, they deserved to die (Shaki 1991). The father could also deprive his children of inheritance only if they disobeyed him (3 times) or became apostates from Zoroastrianism (Christensen, 1935, p. 74; Shaki 1991). The sons were obliged to respect their father as he deserved; otherwise, a part of their paternal inheritance was allocated to the mother provided that she was more competent (Christensen, 2006, 237).

Polygamy and giving birth to a son as a successor ensured the preservation of property within the paternal family and the survival of its offspring (Dezhamkhooy 2012, 3; Mazdapur 1991, 231). Having a son was so important that a form of marriage (čagar-marriage) was designed to produce children for a man who died without a male heir (Christensen 1935, 74-75; 2006, 239; Macuch 2010, 142-143; Mazdapour 1990, 156; Minovi 1975, 67-68). In another type of adoption, the head of the household employed one or more stepfathers and stepmothers from inside or outside his family to legally adopt their son (not daughter) as his own child. This practice was even done by men who already had several children, and they sometimes accepted their grandchildren as adopted children (Macuch 2010, 143-144). If a man was infertile, his wife married another man to give birth to a son for him (Daryaee 2009a, 60-61). All the efforts of the judicial system and the family system in the Sassanid society were to maintain the integrity of lineage and property within the family (Macuch 2010, 145). Among other factors that increased the importance of having children, especially male ones, was the belief that having a child who does good deeds from religious perspective is also an achievement of their father. Interestingly, as much as good deeds of children were effective for the father (Mazdapour 1990, 128-129; Tafazzoli 1975, 45), their sins also affected him after death based on Zoroastrianism (Bahraman 2014, 69).

Although royal family must have been completely different in many ways from a typical family in Sassanian period, these basic traditional-religious rules were also true about this unique family. With Šāh as the center of power pyramid in the era, it is not actually unlikely that these rules were even more severely applied about the Sassanid princes as the potential heirs of the Šāh. This may lead to review the life of princes as far as evidence allow us.

The general situation of the Sassanid princes in the royal family

The evidence gained from the life of the Sassanid kings reveals that the foundations of both royal family and a middle-class family of the Sassanid society were the same. Among the shreds of evidence that shows the importance of family and patriarchal system both among a middle-class family and the royal family are the mention of family lineage addressed in almost all inscriptions of Sassanid kings (Tafazzoli 1997, 86; Lukonin 1971, 40) and also in legal documents associated with the routine life of ordinary people (Dezhamkhooy 2012, 2). Most royal inscriptions include the name, title, name of the father, paternal lineage, and activities of a king, which shows the importance of family lineage, paternal relations, and masculine activities for the Sassanids (Weber 2016).

Like sons in the lower classes, princes were responsible for preserving the generation and property of the Sassanid dynasty. They were also required to pay homage to their father, who had absolute power to make decisions about their lives. The main difference between the royal and a middle-class family was the political roles of both the king and the princess, which often overshadowed or even eliminated their household roles. In addition to the usual duties which boys had towards their fathers and families, the princes were obliged to maintain the monarchy within their lineage, which put them in a perilous and sometimes dangerous position in the Sassanid court. The Sassanid kings put all their efforts into polygamy and reproducing male heirs to keep the power within their house. Having children was so important that if a harem woman were sentenced to death for any reason, her pregnancy was one of the factors that could save her life (Nöldeke 1979, 77-79).

As it is clear in most of the reliefs and other pictorial representations of this period, the role of sons and sometimes male descendants of the king is shown to be the closest to that of the king. For example, the choice of a special place to engrave the image of the children in the reliefs of Ardašir's coronation in Naqš-e Rostam and Naqš-e Rajab undoubtedly indicates a clear intention. The meaning can concern the position of these children as prominent members of the royal family and their relationship with the monarch_father-son relationship (Miri and Jalali 2016, 155-156). Ardašir, while introducing the children, informed everyone that his generation would continue through these princes (Christensen 2006, 61-62; Miri 2017, 69-70). On the rock relief of Ardašir at Firuzābād, he is depicted taking the ring of power from another figure (Ohrmazd), while the crown prince, Šāpur I, and two other princes or aristocrats are standing behind him (Miri and Jalali 2016, 161; S. Shahbazi 2002). Ardašir and Šāpur are shown facing each other on the third type of Ardašir's coins which may have been struck to introduce Šāpur as the crown prince (Shahbazi 2002; Wiesehöfer 1986).

Other works, in which the crown prince is portrayed with Šāh, include the rock relief of Šāpur I in Naqš-e Rajab (Miri 2017, 69-70), Narseh in Naqš-e Rostam (Christensen 2006, 170-171; Miri 2017, 71; Weber 2016), Šāpur III (Šāpur Kermān Šāh) with Šāpur II and Ardašir I and his two sons, and Bahrām II in Sar Mašhad and the Naqš-e Rostam and his coins in which the crown prince Bahrām III is depicted with the king (Dezhamkhooy 2012, 2; Shahbazi 1988). The names of the Sassanid princes are sometimes taken from the name of their fathers, grandfather, or proud ancestors, and this reference may indicate that they took their identity from their fathers or ancestors and followed them in ruling the empire. The Šāh may also have personally allocated these names to them to indicate that they were obedient agents of him (Dezhamkhooy 2012, 2; Frye, 1962, 209-210).

Among the other differences between the royal and middle-class families were the way of bringing up princes and the criteria by which the head of the royal family, the next king, was appointed. The upbringing of children was completely under the supervision of women at home until the age of five in the upper classes of society, and the training, in its technical sense, began from this age (Bartholomae 1958, 42). Like the Achaemenids, the sons of the Sassanid nobilities

learned the way of aristocracy in the court under the supervision of one of the great officials (Nöldeke 1979, 665) as Pāpak obtained permission from Gōzihr, the king of Eṣṭakr to place his son in the care of Tīrī, the commandant of the castle of Dārābgerd (Wiesehöfer 1986). From the list of Kōsrow II Parvēz charges presented by Qobād Šīrōy, one can conclude that the kings were obliged to treat the princes well. They had to arrange for the princes to associate with clergies and aristocrats and provide their living expenses, education facilities, and marriage requirements (Christensen 2006, 354-355; Nöldeke 1979, 535).

On the other hand, we find hints about the importance of playing games along with training, practicing, and selecting the right group of playmates for children and teenagers, at least among the aristocrats and the royal family. Ardavān was happy when he saw Ardašīr playing polo skillfully and ordered him to play it every day, according to *The Kār-Nāmag ī Ardašīr ī Pāpakān* (Grenet 2003, 60). Moreover, the deprivation of the game is presented as a punishment for Ardašīr, confirming its value for children and adolescents (Miri and Jalali 2016, 155). When Ardašīr wanted to evaluate the identity of his son, Šāpur I, he ordered the boy to play polo with several boys of the same age with similar clothes and physiques in front of the palace. Ardašīr recognized Šāpur I at first sight, and the boy proved his worthiness when he dared to enter the royal porch alone and fearlessly approaching the king to regain the lost ball. The meeting ended happily, and Šāpur I was proclaimed heir to the throne (al-Tabari 1999, 26-27; Shahbazi 2002;). Hormozd I had also learned to play polo as one of the compulsory games taught to princes and nobles (al-Tabari 1999, 41; Nöldeke 1979, 102).

Another different case about the royal family was the way of selecting the future successor. Whereas, in an ordinary family, the eldest son was in charge of general affairs after the death or disability of the Sālār, family guardianship was interwoven into the monarchy in the Sassanid house, and the role was not simply assigned to the eldest prince. The choice depended on a variety of circumstances, including the maternal family of a prince, his combat capabilities, his experience in ruling imperial states such as Sakastān, his adherence to the Mazdaean religion, and so on.

Given that the paternal family of princes was the same, it was the maternal lineage that determined their rank and chance for taking the throne (al-Tabari 1999, 379-380; Nöldeke 1979, 522-524). It seems that the greater the house of the mother of a prince, the higher the prince's position was. More specifically, the support of mother's relatives who usually had high ranks in the court determined the prince's chance of winning the throne.

While explaining the descent of Hormozd to Ardašīr, Šāpur fell to the ground and confessed his guilt; Considering that the mother of Hormozd was the daughter of Mehrak Šāh, one of Ardašīr's enemies, it shows that marrying the daughter of an enemy was considered a great mistake for princes (Bal'ami 1974, 899; Nöldeke 1979, 101-102) and may even put their lives in great danger. Fry (1962) also argues that the neglect of Bahrām I in the first list of Šāpur's distinguished sons in the inscription of the Ka'ba-ye Zardošt and the fact that Šāpur did not assign a personal fire (fire temple) to him may have been due to the low status of his maternal lineage and Bahrām I probably has been significantly deprived of his rights as a prince (Weber 2016). The traces of Sukrā, of the Karin family, who was Kawād's maternal uncle, was evident in the dethronement of Walāxš I and the appointment of Kawād as the new king (Schindel 2013). In a folk-tale about Kōsrow I

Anōšīravān's mother, there is also a trace of the influence of the mother clan on the status of princes; According to Bal'ami's history, Ƙosrow I Anōšīravān had a peasant mother whom Kawād decided to bring to the court considering the death of Walāxš, his brother who left the throne for Kawād, might be related to the woman's good luck (Bal'ami 1974, 964-965). This incident also shows the complete authority of the father to accept or reject his children (Bartholomae 1958, 40; Mazdapour 1991, 230).

Although this story is fictitious, Christensen mentions that Kawād brought the mother and the son to court after finding the value of her old and famous background in the household (Christensen 2006, 256). Kawād had ten sons, but he loved Anōšīravān and his peasant mother more (Bal'ami 1974, 967) indicating that sometimes family bonds overcame political considerations. The high position of Hormozd's mother (daughter of Khaqan) was also the main reason for which Ƙosrow I Anōšīravān preferred him over other princes, all of whom were born from peasant mothers (Bal'ami 1974, 1070-1071; Nöldeke 1979, 409; Ya'qubi 2003, 204; Shahbazi 2004b; Howard-Johnston 2000). During the overthrowing of Hormozd IV, Beštām and Bendōy, the maternal uncles of Ƙosrow II Parvēz, were the main perpetrators of the revolt (Howard-Johnston 2000; Shahbazi, 2004b). It again shows the role of the prince's maternal lineage in his accession to the throne; besides, Nöldeke considers Qobād Šīrōy's only advantage over Mardānšah, the famous lineage of Maryam, Qobād Šīrōy's mother (Nöldeke 1979, 475). Although the mother of Yazdegerd III was a member of the court crew she was introduced as the daughter of a reputable family that was clearly an adjustment done to respect the monarchy and the prince in terms of public opinion (Nöldeke 1979, 570).

Among other determining factors in establishing the position of a prince was his adherence to the religion of his ancestors, the Mazdaean faith (Bal'ami 1974, 907). It is evident from various acts of the kings, such as introducing themselves in inscriptions and coins as Mazda worshippers, striking the image of a fireplace on their coins, their investiture by Ohrmazd and Mithra, and persecuting the religious minorities, for instance. The princes must have retained the official religion of the country; otherwise, they either became the object of anger of the king and the court, such as Anušagzad, the Christian son of Ƙosrow I Anōšīravān or deprived of the kingship like Kāus Patišwāršāh due to his allegiance to Mazdakites (Christensen, 2006, 256; Nöldeke 1979, 707-708). Although the mother of princes had various religious beliefs like Šōšanduxt who was a daughter of the Jewish exilarch and gave birth to Bahrām V Gōr (Daryaee 2009a, 78; Klíma 1988; Shahbazi 2003), the princes had to adhere to the Zoroastrian religion for gaining the support of clerics and aristocrats before and after taking the throne. Adherence to the Mazdaean faith was so important that even powerful kings such as Kawād I, who sought to moderate the power of clerics via supporting new doctrines, such as Mazdakite were ousted because of turning away from the official religion.

The political roles of the Sassanid princes

The political policy had to be shaped by the relationship between the king, royal family, and landlords (including members of the old Parthian aristocracy) from the earliest days of the monarchy in the Sassanid dynasty (Wiesehöfer 1986). The royal family, the princes, had several

political roles that made them the key, yet dangerous, court members, whose presence was essential to the dynasty's survival, and the king's power depended on them.

Princes as the king's reliable allies: Princes appeared as the main and trusted allies in wars due to their blood relationship with the king; Šāpur I accompanied his father in Ardašir's campaign against the Parthians and in the battle of Hormozgān (Christensen 2006, 60-61; Shahbazi 2002). In the relief of Dārābgerd, Šāpur wears the crown of Ardašir which symbolically depicted the joint victory of father and son. Penetrating deep into Syria to the coast and plundering what he found, Šāpur was leading an army to the depths of Syria, while Hormozd-Ardašir invaded Lesser Armenia and Cappadocia (Shahbazi 2002; Shayegan 2004). Among the reliefs of Bahrām II, there are two commemorations of victories in Naqš-e Rostam, one related to Bahrām himself and the other probably related to one of the princes who defeated two enemies (Shahbazi 1988). Ardašir, the half-brother of Šāpur II, seems to have been involved in Šāpur II's victories against Rome because he portrayed the Roman emperor under his horse in the relief in Tāq-e Bostān (Shahbazi 1986).

During Pērōz's first campaign against the Hephtalites, he and Kawād, his son, were captured in a battle near Gorgān. In a treaty with the Hephtalite ruler, Pērōz was obliged to commit himself to maintaining permanent peace and to pay a cash ransom. Only then could Pērōz and his army depart. Kawād, however, was kept hostage for two years by the Hephtalites. Firuz's next campaign against the Hephtalites was accompanied by several princes who were likely to assist him in the war (Schippmann 1999). Following the division of the Hephtalite kingdom between Persia and the Turks during the reign of Kōsrow I Anōšīravān, Sinjibu (Silzibul) (k̄āqān of Turks) endangered the borderlands of eastern Persia. Kōsrow sent his son, Hormozd, to deal with him and as a result of political negotiations, the k̄āqān retreated to his territory. Considering that Hormozd was the granddaughter of Sinjibu, Kōsrow seems to have known that by sending Hormozd to war against his grandfather, he could avert the danger without huge damage or difficulty (Shahbazi 2004b).

Princes as rulers of the imperial states: Princes also served the king as trustworthy rulers for administrating and securing important imperial territories like Armenia, Sīstān, Gēlān, and Mēšān. To determine how vital this task was, we must notice the importance of gaining control of these regions for the rise of the Sassanid dynasty to power. There was no unified empire by the end of the Parthian period and power was separated among the Parthians in Media and Mesopotamia and the Indo-Parthians in the east, besides some small kingdoms in Persia, Elam, and other areas between Jaxartes and Euphrates (Rezakhani 2017, 45). Although Ardašir was able to defeat Ardavān, it was only after his victory over Farn-Sasan, as the last Indo-partian king, that Ardašir could call himself 'Šāhān Šāh' since Farn-Sasan's rank and political power were higher than Ardašir (Rezakhani 2017, 39-40). Furthermore, the Indo-Parthian ancestors of Farn-Sasan were the most central political institution in most parts of eastern Persia from two centuries before the rise of the Sassanids. Such a defeat was a confirmation of the power of Ardašir and the establishment of a new empire (Rezakhani 2017, 30).

Sīstān and Marv (Rezakhani 2017, 27) were considered a gateway for the subjugation of the whole of eastern Iranian domain; later, it was necessary to entrust the administration of these states to the most trusted agents of the king, namely his sons and especially the princes who were more likely to ascend the throne one day and should be prepared for the monarchy in order to preserve

such strategic areas and consolidate imperial power there (Daryaee 2009a, 6; Christensen 2006, 72). According to Tabari, Šāpur II established cities in Sind and Sīstān among his urban development projects to confirm his rule over the region. Finally, most of the gold coins minted by Šāpur II came from Eastern territories such as Marv, where the Kušān simultaneously minted gold coins. There are also many copper coins from the Sakastān and Kabul mints. It may mean that Šāpur II was able to extract enormous amounts of gold and other precious metals from his eastern enemies (Daryaee 2009b). Many princes, some of whom were also major candidates for the throne, were appointed by the king to govern principal areas of the empire. Among the Sassanid princes, who ruled the eastern regions of the empire, we can name Ardašir, son of Ardašir I, who ruled Kermān during the reign of his father (Bal'ami 1974, 879; Christensen 2006, 59; Frye 1962, 209-210). Šāpur I, Hormozd I (Bal'ami 1974, 899), Bahrām I, and Bahrām II governed Ƙorāsān and Kušān before raising as kings.

Among the sons of Šāpur I, Narseh was the ruler Hind (estān), Sakastān, and Turān to the Edge of the Sea, and Šāpur was Mēšān Šāh (King of Mesene) (Shahbazi 2002; Weber 2016). Šāpurs decision on handing over this vast territory to Narseh is a testament to his belief and trust in the ability of his son. Narseh probably played a key role in Sassanid Eastern politics (Weber 2016). Also, Bahrām II assigned his son, Bahrām, as the governor of Sīstān after defeating Hormozd's revolt that lasted for several years (Bal'ami 1974, 903; Shahbazi 1988). Ardašir II was the governor of Adiaben, and Vahram IV was the ruler of Kermān and had the title of Kermān Šāh (Klíma 1988). Šāpur I appointed Hormozd I as the governor of Ƙorāsān (Nöldeke 1979, 102-103), a post by which he could also practice for kingship (Nöldeke 1979, 120). Bahrām, the son of Šāpur II, became the king of Kermān and his title was Kermān Šāh (Nöldeke 1979, 120). Hormozd III was also the king of Sakastān (Nöldeke 1979, 199). Another region of great importance for the Sassanid kings was Armenia which, for centuries, formed a disputed area between the Sassanids and Romans. Hormozd I (Hormozd Ardašir) was the ruler of Armenia and among the sons of Yazdegerd I, Šāpur IV was appointed as the king of a part of Armenia that belonged to Persia (Christensen 2006, 199; Daryaee 2009a, 71; Shahbazi 2003; Nöldeke 1979, 186).

There were also other states under the supervision of princes like Gilan, which was ruled by Bahrām I (Gēlān Šāh). Kāus, the eldest son of Kawād I, took over the governorship of Patišwārgar (Ṭabarestān) after the collapse of the Gošnāsb dynasty, which had dominated it since the end of the Parthian era (Christensen 2006, 255). Ƙosrow II Parvēz was also appointed to rule Albania before ascending to the throne and was called Alān Šāh (Howard-Johnston 2000; Shahbazi 2004b).

There were various motives for appointing the princes as rulers of the salient imperial states. Taking preparation for the duties of a king was one of the main reasons as shown by the fact that the court cited lack of experience in governing for the ineligibility of Bahrām V to succeed Yazdegerd (Nöldeke 1979, 158). Other reasons include driving princes away from the capital and eliminating the possibility of their revolt, satisfying their ambition to some extent, and finally leaving the strategic and key areas that were constantly invaded by various enemies to someone reliable. This strategy made the power of the Sassanid dynasty in areas such as Sīstān so strong that even after the death of the last Sasanian king, Yazdegerd III, in Marv on 651 AD, his son,

Peroz, was able to remain in power in Zarang (of Sīstān) until 673, 674 or 675 with the support of the Tang government in China (Agostini and STARK 2016, 18-19).

Princes as guarantors of alliances of cooperation with political rivals and peace with enemies: Political marriages among kings, princes, and nobles and the daughters of their allies and opponents were a practical and long-term solution to expand, stabilize, and survival the power of the king since ancient times (Christensen 2006, 229; Frye 1962, 207); In the inscription of Narseh in Paikuli, it is interesting that the name of the Sagān Bāmbēšn (Sakān Queen) and Narsehdokht, Sagān Bānug (Sakān Lady) comes along with the names of Šāpurdokht and the Crown Prince as the list of immediate family members of the king (Weber 2016). Narseh married the daughter of one of the influential nobles in east territory to ensure their loyalty to the Sassanid family during his rule over the region. Kawād I fled to the king of the Huns after being deposed by clergies and aristocrats, married the daughter of the king, and finally forced his father-in-law to give him an army to win the throne back (Schindel 2013; Nöldeke 1979, 239-240). Kōsrow I Anōšīravān also allied with the Turkish Kāqān, Sinjibu, to destroy the power of the Heptalites and married his daughter. Later, he used this bond to prevent Kāqān from advancing into Persia borders by sending his son, Hormozd, who also was Kāqān's grandson in the war (Shahbazi 2004b). It also seems that Kōsrow II Parvēz married Maryam who has been introduced as a Roman princess solely for political reasons.

The Sassanid kings' approach toward the princes

Although the Sassanid princes were primarily considered the most focal factor in implementing the king's orders and policies due to their blood relationship with the king, their numerous political roles and vital dependence of the king to them as his successors and the guardians of the monarchy within the Sassanid dynasty made the king always take a conservative approach towards his sons. It was advised to the king to be amiable in dealing with his family in the 12 principles of Bozorgmehr's statehood for Kōsrow (Nawabi 1959, 305 & 315; Nöldeke 1979, 408), a popular-religious andarz composition in Pahlavi. Šāh was also expected to behave well with the princes, arrange for them to associate with the nobles, provide their living expenses and education, and organize their marriage (Christensen 2006, 354-355; Nöldeke 1979, 535). However the king, both as the family head and as the main element of the flexible dictatorial system on which the Sassanid Empire was based, had the absolute power to decide about the life of his sons, which made their relationship different, and in many cases, more violent than a father-son relationship in the middle-class families of the Sassanid society (Nöldeke 1979, 473).

Asawārān and princes formed the first class in the court of Kōsrow (Christensen 2006, 265 & 289), which placed the princes in the highest political and social position after the king. They sat at the shortest distance from the king in official ceremonies (Christensen 2006, 289). They were also required to pay formal homage to their father (the king) and were not allowed to work at the royal court because they constantly competed causing their authority and glory to diminish in the court (Christensen 2006, 73-72). Šāpur lived in a separate house (palace) from Ardašīr, as mentioned in the incident that result in revealing Hormozd's true identification to Ardašīr (Bal'ami 1974, 899).

According to the Letter of Tansar, Ardašir decided that the Crown Prince should not be elected by the king so that there would be no animosity and enmity between the princes over it, and the Crown Prince would not take action against the Šāh, the Šāh would not become suspicious of him, and the enemies would not seek to destroy the Crown Prince (Christensen 1935, 178-179; Minovi 1975, 73). As we know, Ardašir appointed Šāpur I as his successor who also reigned with his father for a short time (Nöldeke 1979, 69; Wiesehöfer 1986), but considering that the Letter of Tansar was compiled centuries after the reign of Ardašir, one could suggest the complexity of the relationship between the king and the princes later by closely examining the reasons for not choosing the crown prince by a king. The Sassanid king had to manage the disputes between the princes, prevent the coup or revolt of the princes, and prevent the enemies from assassinating the elected crown prince. All these issues have caused the personal bond between the king and the princes to be so weakened. It was to the extent that the princes, like other court members, were not allowed to enter the king's room without the official permission of their father (Christensen 2006, 291).

On the other hand, the nobles and clerics had been constantly trying to disrupt the relationship between the king and princes to gain more power at court; for example, Hormozd I was accused of rebellion against Šāpur I and forced to cut off his hand to prove his innocence from this fatal charge as physical disability of a prince abdicate him from becoming a king (Bal'ami 1974, 899-900). However, Hormozd reigned after his father for a brief time despite his disability revealing that this law might be violated and had not always been observed. The complexity of the relationship between a king and his sons is obvious from the incident that happened between Šāpur and Hormozd; their kinship bond made them survive the difficulty of their political relationship but was not that strong to acquit Hormozd without any damage. The court probably had a problem with Hormozd, and the reason for his short reign was also their opposition against him (Nöldeke 1979, 102-103).

The appointment of Bahrām II as the successor of Bahrām I, despite the presence of Narseh as a legitimate claimant of the throne, was another manifestation of the contrast between a king's political role and family role which eventually led to a great war within royal family twenty years later (Weber 2016). Bahrām I certainly considered his son more worthy than his stepbrother, Narseh. Although the latter had proved his sufficiency for the monarchy by ruling over the vast area of eastern Iran. On the contrary, Bahrām II had no political experience or achievement before throning (at least as far as we know). In practice, he expressed more interest in family affairs such as protecting the queen and the prince from a lion or giving flowers to the queen as portrayed in his rock reliefs (Christensen 2006, 167-168; Daryaee, 2009a, 11) rather than his duties as a monarch which perhaps was the principal cause of significant raise of the political power of Kartir and other priests during his reign (Lukonin 1971, 175-176). It seems that ignorance of Bahrām I by his father (Šāpur I), which is obvious from the Naqš-e Rostam inscription (Weber 2016), finally was manifested in Bahrām I's decision to deprive Narseh of being the next king. Later, Narseh tried to restore more power to the royal family, but the court who freed themselves from the successors of Narseh after his short reign, placed the crown on the head of an unborn (Šāpur II) which gave them power for a long time (Nöldeke 1979, 106 -107). Bal'ami mentioned that Ardašir (older brother of Šāpur II) was deprived of kingship due to a dispute with Bahrām II (918), but it

seems that the power of the clerics and aristocrats had increased at this stage that they were able to elect an infant as the king despite the presence of an adult prince (Bal'ami 1974, 904).

Šāpur II's policy regarding the succession of his son Šāpur III was directly opposed to Bahrām I; Šāpur II seemingly knew that if he wanted the monarchy to pass to his son without any internal disputes, had to recognize the right of his brother, Ardašir, for kingship. Ardašir was also a strong ally in Šāpur's wars against Rome. Therefore, Ardašir was appointed as the successor of Šāpur by promising that he would resign in favor of Šāpur III after his puberty (Shahbazi 1986).

One of the methods used by the Sassanid kings to resolve disputes caused by princes and punish them was to deport them to areas far from the capital to live under supervision; Yazdegerd I deported Bahrām V to Hira due to a disagreement happened between them (Christensen 2006, 199; Klíma 1988; Nöldeke 1979, 185). When Bahrām V became an adult, he decided to see his father. However, Bahrām asked the Roman ambassador to seek his father's permission for Bahrām's return to Hira a year later since Yazdegerd was so tyrannical that Bahrām could not ask him directly. Bahrām's relationship was better with his guardian, Monzer, than with his father (Bal'ami 1974, 931-932) because Monzar sent Bahrām money as Yazdegerd deprived him of financial resources (Nöldeke 1979, 157).

Kawād, who once being ousted, knew for sure that he had to do his best to fix the succession of his son, Kōsrow I Anōšīravān. The massacre of Mazdakite leaders can be called a demonstration of Kōsrow I Anōšīravān's complete dedication to the religion of his fathers done under the closed supervision of Kawād. It was also mentioned that he has peacefully solved the potential danger orienting from his second son, Jam, who was blind in one eye (Christensen 2006, 256). Kawād even asked the Roman emperor Justin to support Kōsrow I Anōšīravān to assure his reign (Schindel 2013).

There were some examples of blinding or mutilating rebellious princes (Christensen 1935, 134; 2006, 190 & 221); Anušagzad revolted against his father, Kōsrow, when he was seriously ill. Kōsrow suppressed the revolt but did not kill Anušagzad and was satisfied with blinding him (Christensen 2006, 275; Nöldeke 1979, 712).

Another example of an attempt of the high officials to disrupt the father-son relationship in the royal family occurred when Bahrām Čōbin minted coins in the name of Kōsrow II Parvēz with the intention of pessimizing Hormozd against his son (Bal'ami 1974, 1080-1081; Nöldeke 1979, 471; Ya'qubi 2003, 206). Later, Kōsrow showed tacit consent for blinding and murdering his father, Hormozd, by Beštām and Bendōy (Bal'ami 1974, 1082; Christensen 2006, 317). It seems that Hormozd IV was very oppressive and tyrannical to the extent that Kōsrow II Parvēz also collaborated with his uncles to depose him (Nöldeke 1979, 391). The narrative of taking compensation from Kōsrow for the damage done to the peasants shows that Hormozd was hard on the princes (Bal'ami 1974, 1071-1072; Nöldeke 1979, 385-386). The fact that Hormozd still guided Kōsrow during the revolt of Bahrām Čōbin despite being ousted and blinded (Nöldeke 1979, 392) again shows the contrast between the family role and the political role of the Sassanid kings and princes.

Kosrow II Parvēz, who managed his sons by imprisoning them, claimed that he did so to prevent the princes from interfering in the political affairs which may harm the country and the people (Nöldeke 1979, 535). It can be said that the Sassanid king had to disregard his family relations to maintain his political power, and this fact caused him to see his sons as potential dangers to the monarchy.

Sassanid princes' approach toward the king

Political considerations and the position of a prince at the court were the foremost factors in determining the prince's approach toward his father. Sassanid princes usually followed one out of two approaches to their father; Depending on the circumstances or their relationship with the Sassanid king, they either wanted to continue the father's model for the monarchy, or they wanted to separate their way from the father. Among the princes who had a good relationship with their father and tried to keep the memory of the deceased king was Šāpur I who not only had established cities in his father's name but also reigned with his father; though, for a short while. The prince also continued the father's strict policy toward the Jews during his early reign, which might be an attempt to expand the Mazdaean community (Wiesehöfer 1986). Although the Sassanid kingdom was nascent at this time, the cooperation of the father (Ardašir) and the son (Šāpur) in wars and the implementation of Ardašir's politics over the vast areas of the Sassanid empire levered to strengthening their power and led ultimately to the entire stability of the monarchy.

The sons of Yazdegerd III were the last princes who tried to take political advantage of their father's influence by minting coins with Yazdegerd's name and image after the collapse of the Sassanid Empire by Arab invasion (Daryaei 2015, 60).

Other princes such as Bahrām I and his son, Bahrām II, ended the policy of religious tolerance of their predecessors and persecuted followers of non-Mazdaean religions, including Jews, Buddhists, Hindus, Mandaean, Jainas, Manichaeans, and Christians (Weber 2016). This policy change was most likely due to the circumstances in which the two kings came to power. Considering that Bahrām's name is not mentioned among Šāpur's distinguished sons in his inscription on the Ka'ba-ye Zardošt (Ka'ba of Zoroaster) and Šāpur did not found a special fire for the prince (Weber 2016), Bahrām I most likely did not have the necessary family support to take the throne compared to Narseh. Bahrām may have been forced to establish another base in the court by empowering clerics when he came to power. Bahrām II also continued his father's policy and raised the power of clerics specially Kartir. Being deprived of the monarchy for twenty years, Narseh sought to reduce the power of courtiers and clerics and to stop the policy of persecution of religious minorities encouraged by Bahrām I and II (Weber 2016). Later his son, Hormozd II, re-adopted this policy (Shahbazi 2004a), which could have been due to his need for the support of aristocrats and clerics.

From all these incidents and changes in attitudes towards the common fates of Persia, one can conclude that the circumstances in which a prince came to power were the most determining factor for the approach he took toward the policies of the previous king and was not necessarily due to father-son relationship between the king and the princes. Sometimes the previous king had lost the support of the high officials of the Sassanid court, and the prince tried to take a completely different

path from his father after becoming the king for consolidating his position. Among these princes was Bahrām V Gor, who explicitly stated taking a path opposed to that of his oppressive father (Bal'ami 1974, 935-936; Nöldeke 1979, 161) because the aristocrats and clerics decided to deprive Yazdegerd's children of the kingship after murdering him and his eldest son Ardašir (Klíma 1988; Shahbazi 2003). The power of the elders had increased so much by the time of Bahrām V Gor, who sought help from the Arabs to support him, and he promised the court that he would compensate for his father's wrongdoings (Klíma 1988). We can see that family bonds between the members of Sassanid dynasty had been completely canceled out by their political role at this point when Bahrām V handed over the governance to the courtiers and nobles who killed his father and brother with full consent without punishing the perpetrators. One of the reasons that facilitated this approach of Bahrām could be his exile to Hirah and growing up away from the royal family. Moreover, Ardašir was Bahrām's step-brother who mostly considered as a rival in contrary to Narseh, his full brother, who expectedly appointed as the king of *Ḳorāsān* later (Klíma 1988).

Yazdegerd II was depicted as a king interested in the prosperity of the country, justice, not as fierce as his grandfather, and did not follow the way of his father in hunting, feasting, and long parties. Considering the political performance of the king concerning the persecution of religious minorities that had begun during the reign of Šāpur II to consolidate the Sassanid power on the western borders of the empire (Daryaee 2000), it can be said that Yazdegerd adopted a policy in favor of Zoroastrian clergies to stable his position as the king. Meanwhile, he had not delegated power to them like Bahrām V and played an active role in governing the empire's affairs.

When the Kawād came to power, the power and prestige of the Sassanid kings had reached its weakest point, and he was able to hand over a stable and powerful kingdom to his son *Ḳosrow* I, 43 years later, which could equal the military resources of the Byzantine Empire. Given the challenges that Kawād faced during his reign, he was undoubtedly one of the most powerful and successful figures of the Sassanid dynasty who was also a genius of his kind (Schindel 2013). Although his eldest son, Kāus Patišwāršāh, had the support of the Mazdakites, he did his best to make *Ḳosrow* sit on the throne without any problem (Nöldeke 1979, 217-248-249). The father and son also collaborated in tax reforms that eventually brought the aristocratic lands under the direct control of the Sassanids (Wiesehöfer 1986), as well as eliminating the Mazdakite threat to the throne.

However, one can see a relatively negative image of the Kawād as a weak ruler, whom his son easily surpasses in the tradition of Eastern historiography, especially Tabari. It is clearly due to the propaganda that *Ḳosrow* I used after he came to the throne (Schindel 2013). Apparently, the relationship between Kawād and *Ḳosrow* I Anōšīravān was mostly based on political relations, and *Ḳosrow* was so overshadowed by his father's power that he made every effort to downplay his father's successful actions after reaching the monarchy. Subsequently, we face the competition of Hormozd IV with his father, *Ḳosrow* I Anōšīravān, to excel in justice which could be one of the reasons for Hormozd to be ousted later. Hormozd IV's support of the lower classes and his strictness toward noble families did not end well, and both nobles and common people eventually revolted against him (Shahbazi 2004b). Once the Sassanid kings had greater power than the elders and clerics, they tried to compete with their fathers. There are several examples of sons who

competed with their fathers to get out of the shadow of their achievements in history, and the Sassanid princes were no exception.

Ḳosrow had tacit or complete (Shahbazi 2004b) consent for blinding and murdering Hormozd, his father, by Beštām and Bendōy who were Ḳosrow's uncles (Bal'ami 1974, 1082; Christensen 2006, 317; Howard-Johnston 2000). According to the belief of the Jews, Christians, and Zoroastrians, whoever kills a father, the inheritance of their father would be forbidden for them; otherwise, he would be condemned (Bal'ami 1974, 1180). Perhaps because of such beliefs, the princes, like Ḳosrow II Parvēz and Qobād Širōy, who were involved in the overthrow and murder of their fathers tried to absolve themselves of the sin in some way (Bal'ami 1974, 1081-1082 & 1168-1169). When a prince rebelled against his father, he had no choice but to kill his father as the deposed king might take his power back and punish both the prince and the nobles who were involved in the conspiracy against him (Bal'ami 1974, 1181-1182; Ya'qubi 2003, 212-213). To acquit themselves of the charge of murdering their father, the princes did it through intermediaries, then punished the murderer (Bal'ami 1974, 1184-1185; Ya'qubi 2003, 213). It seems that the punishment of Hormozd's murderers was not merely revenge, Ḳosrow II Parvēz also sought to destroy the political power of his uncles. After Ḳosrow's reign, Bendōy and Beštām were undoubtedly the chief men in his new regime; Bendōy took charge of the government at the center, and Beštām was assigned the most important army command, as *spāhbed* of Ḳorāsān (Howard-Johnston 2000). Ḳosrow, who was certainly dissatisfied with the supervision of his uncles removed them from his path as soon as he came to power under the pretext of punishing his father's killers.

Although Ḳosrow II Parvēz had achieved brilliant political achievements, he was a king who had managed his relationship with the princes by imprisoning them (Bal'ami 1974, 1146-1147). With his weakening and the election of Mardānšah, Širin's eldest son, as successor, Ḳosrow's last political mistake was made, which eventually led to the vacancy of the monarchy. In the struggle of the survivors, the Sassanid realm was left unprotected, and the end of Ḳosrow II Parvēz's reign can be considered the beginning of the fall of the Sassanid empire (Daryaee 2009a, 34-35; Emrani 2009, 6). He intended to deprive Qobād Širōy as the main claimant of the crown prince title, contrary to the existing beliefs and laws, and to replace him with Mardānšah, son of Širin (Shirin). Most of Ḳosrow's sons must have been Qobād Širōy supporters, so the rebellious elders had good reason to take Qobād Širōy to the throne (Howard-Johnston 2000; Nöldeke 1979, 568). Qobād Širōy tried to erase the memory of his father, Ḳosrow II Parvēz (Daryaee 2015, 60) despite constructing a tomb for Ḳosrow II Parvēz and punishing the perpetrators of his murder after he had implicitly agreed to kill his father (Christensen 2006, 353-355; Nöldeke 1979, 542). The true nature of these actions seems to be just a political consideration that Qobād Širōy had to comply.

Conclusion

In the early Sassanid period, kings not only had the main power in managing the affairs of the country but also were in charge of affairs and decisions in their own families, which is well shown in the inscription of Šāpur I. Šāpur I mentioned his political achievements in this inscription, introduced his family and determined the political role of his sons. There was an order in the family relations of the king reflecting the order of the Sassanid Empire, especially via princes appointed

as the governor of the different regions to ensure their father's power over these areas and gain some experience for governing the whole empire in the future as the potential heir of Šāpur I.

Several branches had emerged from the very extended royal family after Šāpur I's reign which each of his successors considered himself the worthiest of the monarchy. The excessive expansion of the royal family and the complex relations between its members during the Sassanid period, in general, constantly fueled the conflicts in the Sassanid court. The culmination of these clashes were the revolts started by Narseh and Qobād Širōy. The claim of Narseh's successor has contrasted with the claim of the successors of Bahrām I. Although the relationship between the king and his sons was still strong during this period, the rise of Kartīr and other priests caused the clergy and aristocracy to use the princes against the Sassanid kings. The princes no longer saw the king as the absolute ruler; thus, situations arose when a potential successor decides to claim the kingship before his father had deceased, which might also have been due to the diminishing of their bond with the king as father.

The Sassanid kings were always in conflict with their political and family roles, and it was complicated to maintain a balance between the two roles, which sometimes were even opposed to each other; if the king was not careful enough, this situation led to a disaster. The princes, on the other hand, had to be cautious about their father, who mostly was seen as the king of a great dynasty. Hence, the father-son relationship was mostly overshadowed by their political roles as the monarch and the prince, which sometimes strengthened the Sassanid empire and sometimes weakened it.

Although many factors have been involved in determining phases of weakness and strength of the Sassanid Empire, the importance of the relations within the royal family, especially the relationship of kings with princes, cannot be ignored. This relationship gradually became less personal and more political influencing the fate of the Sassanid government. The most obvious manifestation of this elaborated situation is evident from the murder of Kōsrow II Parvēz and his sons by Qobād Širōy. Considering the behavior of each king toward their children, their actions, and political decisions, in which the princes were also involved, we can conclude that the kings who could balance their political and personal relationship with their sons and the court were also more successful in managing the dynasty. Ardašir gave his father political advice and tackled the issue of his succession to such an extent that he and Šāpur sat together on the throne, albeit for a fleeting time. One of the greatest coordination between the royal and paternal roles can be seen during the Šāpur I reign, in which each of the sons was assigned to govern a province, and the crown prince was elected without any objection from other princes. However, the father-son relationship between the king and the princes became more influenced by political conditions with the excessive power of the priests and nobles and their involvement in appointing a successor to the point that Kōsrow II Parvēz and Qobād Širōy killed their fathers for taking the power. On the other hand, kings who faced the rebellion of their children were content to blind or mutilate them.

In summary, the princes were the key elements of power for the Sassanid king that also had the potential to put the monarchy in a great danger. This dual characteristic forced the sovereigns to take a cautious attitude toward their sons, which eventually made their kinship bond weakened to

the extent that the father and his sons turned into absolute political rivals, continuously fighting over the throne, and finally leaving the borders open for the Arab invasion.

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